

Rafael Polutta

hejrafa.com

contact@hejrafa.com

+49 176 6159 80 90

Product designer with 11+ years of experience designing useful, accessible digital products across mobile apps, design systems, and complex product interfaces. Deep expertise in UI design, interaction design, and design system architecture – from component definition and design tokens through to designer-engineer workflow and design QA. Thrives as a senior individual contributor in small, focused teams where craft, clarity, and shipping matter. Open to relocation with support.

Experience

UI Design Lead, Phrase / 2020–Present

Joined as the sole product designer with no design system in place; scaled the design team from 1 to 12 designers through structured hiring, onboarding, and mentoring programmes.

- Architected Syntax, Phrase's shared design system – defining the full component library, design tokens, Figma file structure, accessibility standards (WCAG), and contribution guidelines adopted across all product squads.
- Established designer-engineer collaboration workflow and design handoff practices, reducing rework and improving design-to-development velocity across multiple cross-functional product teams.
- Mentored two product designers at a time, supporting their growth into senior individual contributor roles through structured critique sessions, written feedback, and career development planning.
- Advocated for dedicated engineering ownership of the design system, transitioning it from a spare-time maintenance burden into funded product infrastructure – now a dependency for every Phrase product team.
- Maintained product-wide UI quality through regular design reviews, pattern standardisation, and documentation – ensuring interface consistency, interaction design coherence, and accessibility across the Phrase suite.
- Contributed to product strategy and roadmap decisions as the design voice in cross-functional planning, aligning UI direction with business goals and user needs.

Senior Product Designer, Share Now / 2019–2020

Led product design for the merger of car2go and DriveNow into Share Now – a single unified mobile app and brand experience serving users across multiple European cities.

- Designed iOS and Android mobile UX flows centred on trust, familiarity, and clear orientation, enabling millions of existing users from two legacy brands to transition to the new product without friction.
- Delivered end-to-end interaction design, information architecture, and high-fidelity prototypes; collaborated closely with engineering and product management through an agile delivery process.
- Worked across brand identity touchpoints and in-app visual design to maintain coherence between the two merged product identities during a fast-moving integration timeline.

Experience

Product Designer, car2go / 2015–2019

Designed the complete mobile user experience for a global car-sharing product – finding, booking, opening, driving, and ending a trip – across iOS, Android, Windows Phone, and BlackBerry, reaching users across 26 cities and 8 countries.

- Focused on interaction design and information architecture for high-pressure, real-world contexts: calm, clear, fast interfaces for users in the street under time pressure.
- car2go recognised in Time's Top Apps of 2017, reflecting the product's quality, reach, and user adoption at scale.
- Built and maintained component documentation and visual design standards across mobile platforms, contributing to early design system foundations.
- Collaborated directly with engineering teams on design-to-development handoff, interaction specifications, and design QA across multiple platform releases.
- Joined through a six-month product design internship at mytaxi; converted to a full-time product designer role at car2go after five months, taking independent ownership of mobile design.

Freelance Designer / 2012–2022

Delivered end-to-end design engagements for clients including Tomorrow (digital banking) and a San Francisco-based startup – spanning brand identity, product UI design, responsive web design, MVP prototyping, photography, and video production.

- Operated independently across the full design process: concept development, user interface design, visual direction, production, and launch – providing senior-level craft alongside full-time roles for 10 years.
- Designed digital products, marketing sites, and visual identities with a consistent focus on clarity, usability, and craft.

Education

Communications Design & Art Direction / 2012–2015, with Distinction

Studied typography, illustration, photography, video, web and app design, concept development, and writing. Thesis produced as a printed editorial design object.

Product Design

UI design · UX design · Interaction design · Visual design · Prototyping · Wireframing · Information architecture · User-centred design · Design QA · Responsive design · Adaptive design

Design Systems

Design system architecture · Component libraries · Design tokens · Figma · Atomic design · Accessible component defaults · WCAG · Documentation · Contribution guidelines

Mobile

Mobile app design · iOS · Android · Cross-platform design · Windows Phone

Collaboration

Designer-engineer collaboration · Design handoff · Cross-functional teams · Agile · Design leadership · Mentoring · Hiring · Stakeholder communication

Craft

Brand identity · Art direction · Writing · Photography · Video editing · Visual storytelling

Languages

English · German